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Giacomo Gates

Giacomo Gates is a jazz singer in the truest sense of the word. His bop-inflected vocal style upholds the tradition pioneered by King Pleasure, Eddie Jefferson and Jon Hendricks. His latest recording, with original lyrics set to the music of Miles Davis, is entitled "Miles Tones."

Giacomo was interviewed in Utica, NY on March 29, 2015, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and it's 8:30 on a Sunday morning. Jazz musicians just discovered that there are two 8:30s in one day.

GG: I just stayed up all night long so I could make this.

MR: My guest is Giacomo Gates. Thank you for participating with us. And you said about your gig in Utica last night that, "it was full and nobody threw anything."

GG: That's right. That's what makes it successful. No tomatoes? It's a winner.

MR: And because of the hour, I'll start with a really easy question. This is a fill in the blank. Life as a jazz artist is —

GG: An adventure. And interesting. But I wouldn't have it any other way. I did a lot of other things before I did this. I started to do this on a professional level at 39 years old, which is about three or four years ago.

MR: Okay.

GG: And yeah, it's an interesting ride. The whole thing that got me into this, along with the music, because I'm not old enough to have been there when it was really happening. I might have been on the planet in the 1950s, but I wasn't making any clubs. But I was a fan of this music, I still am a fan of the music. I got lucky and took some guitar lessons as a very young kid and my instructors were jazz aficionados, jazz players. So my father played classical music around the house. He also played violin, not as a professional musician, but he played violin. He played pretty good. So I was exposed to classical music, but he also played big bands. He played Basie and Cab Calloway and Ellington and Fletcher Henderson. So I got to hear it. And at a very young age I got turned on to Dave Brubeck, about 1950— I don't know — 7, 8.

MR: Early Brubeck then.

GG: Yeah, early Brubeck. I was probably ten. And I listened to Brubeck and I was taking guitar lessons, and I think I bought — I didn't buy it, my parents bought it for me because I wanted it — the "Time Out" album. And I had no idea what they were doing time-wise. I couldn't — it was brand new to me. And then the next album I got ahold of was Thelonious Monk. So he played in four. But that was a whole 'nother thing too. So that's

kind of where it started and I got hip to Dexter Gordon, Charlie Parker, Lambert, Hendricks & Ross and Joe Williams and on and on and on.

MR: Did you have any peers who shared that interest?

GG: No.

MR: Because the pop of the day was rock & roll.

GG: Yeah. Rhythm & blues, which I mean like Marvin Gaye and the Four Tops and I still am a big fan of James Brown. And my friends were probably listening to — by the time I got into high school — it was rhythm & blues but it was also the Beatles and the Rolling Stones, and like that. And I liked some of that music. But that's not what I dug. You know I would be listening to, I don't know, Savoy Brown Blues Band and then I'd be playing Dexter Gordon and say who's that? Dexter Gordon.

MR: You had a secret you know.

GG: Yeah.

MR: Did you, yesterday, we've just entered the world of Pandora in this house. And we got you up on Pandora, and this tune comes on and my wife goes, "he sounds like Joe Williams."

GG: That's not bad company, thanks.

MR: I wondered if you've always had a mellifluous voice. Did you do the choir thing in school or any of that?

GG: No. No. No. I played guitar as a kid and I sang along with what I played, but I could never play what I heard. I could play the blues, but I couldn't play over "Yardbird Suite." I didn't have the chops. You know, as a kid I learned how to play songs. I didn't learn how to play the guitar. There's a difference. You know what I mean? I learned how to play songs. Melodies and chords. But I didn't learn how to get around on the guitar like I really wanted to. But I played the guitar for maybe eight or nine years so I could read. At least I could speak the musician's language. As a singer, I'm on the bandstand and I'm part of the band, as opposed to in front of the band.

MR: Boy that really is a distinction and I was going to ask you, as a musician who, part of the way you work is to come into town and play with a group and you may or may not have played with some of them or all of them.

GG: Mostly not.

MR: How do you get the sidemen on your side?

GG: I think part of it is the repertoire. Because when I first started to do this, you know, even learning the music, I mean I always dug the *Great American Songbook*. But I sing a jazz repertoire. There's a whole lot of jazz singers out there and they're singing — how many jazz singers does it take to sing "My Funny Valentine"? All of them. So I mean it's a great song but I don't sing it. Chet Baker owns it as far as I'm concerned. But I sing

Thelonious Monk. I sing Charlie Parker. I sing some Dexter Gordon songs. I sing standards, but when I first started to go into New York City when I moved back to Connecticut and I started to go into New York City, there used to be a lot of sessions. And now there aren't. But as a singer, you know, they used to have a sign-up sheet and you'd write down your name and what you play. Well there weren't, and I don't think there are, that many male singers. So I ain't pretty. I know that. So I'm not going to get called up on the bandstand because I'm pretty. "Come on up here, baby and sing" whatever. So I would go up there and sing "Well You Needn't." I'd sing "Yardbird Suite." I'd sing — not a singer's repertoire. And they dug it.

MR: The lyrics, I'm familiar with "Well You Needn't" but I didn't know "Yardbird Suite" had lyrics.

GG: That's very interesting. Because Charlie Parker wrote lyrics to his own song when he was 19 years old, and the song was originally called "What Price Love." Because he left his first wife to go make music. And he wrote the lyrics. And they're really good lyrics too. Nobody knew that he was really a lyricist. And then later on Eddie Jefferson put lyrics to "Yardbird Suite." So I sing 'em both. I sing Bird's first, the band blows, and then I go out with — and they're both kind of historical. I mean you could tell that the first one is about love lost. "What Price Love." And Eddie Jefferson's is about what is the musical topic of the day/bebop so the critics say. Because he wrote 'em in the late 50s.

MR: It's a song about songs.

GG: Yeah, exactly. Exactly.

MR: So if you went up to the bandstand in that situation and you wanted to do a standard, do you feel compelled to do it in the original key or do you — you have your keys together.

GG: Well I'm lucky. A lot of the songs that I sing I sing in the standard key, which certainly makes them happy. I mean you play, you know a good musician can play in any key. But they're comfortable in the keys that the songs are in. I mean if I could sing — you know it does make a difference I mean if I sing something in A flat and in B flat, there's a big difference for me, especially if I'm singing the solo, there's a bigger range, so I need to be in my sweet spot. But you'll make a musician happy if you can call "Well You Needn't" in F as opposed to E flat. Because he's not used to playing it in E flat. So I want them to be able to not think and just play and have a good time, so we can all have a good time as opposed to being busy reading, or, you know, can we do "Lush Life" in D. D? What is that too fast?

MR: I'm going to remember that one. That was a good one. As an aside, Rick Montalbano told me a singer — this is a joke but it really happened.

GG: Go ahead.

MR: The girl wanted to sing a tune and he tried the key and she said, "that's too high, can you do it in minor?" But it begs the question, what makes a singer a musician. And why does that question even exist? Why do some instrumentalists not think of singers as musicians? What causes that?

GG: Well I think that there's probably — certainly there are a lot of singers who are musicians. But there's a whole lot of singers who aren't. And what I mean by that is I mean I learned how to play the piano when I started to sing seriously. But I would never do a gig on the piano because I don't play that well. But I could sit down and play the changes. I can hear the notes that are in the changes. I know what the bridge is as opposed to "the middle." I'm going to come in at the middle or I'm going to come in anywhere. I mean I know the language. I don't speak French but if I only spoke French and you spoke English we'd have a hell of a time communicating. So I want to speak their language. It makes them comfortable, it makes me comfortable. You know it's more than the language, there's a certain — I believe there's a certain protocol up there on the bandstand. I mean I see things that are completely out of whack sometimes, that I see people do, that they shouldn't do. Because it's not protocol.

MR: Can you give me an example?

GG: I mean maybe I'm wrong but I mean, and I don't want to be corny, but the bandstand is kind of a special place. So if there's a trio up on the bandstand, or a riser, or even the floor, it doesn't even have to be a bandstand, you're not supposed to go up there and talk to them and hang out if you don't belong there. You know there's a certain je ne sais quoi that's supposed to happen. And a lot of people don't know about that. And maybe because today it's a different world. Everything is okay. "Sure come on up." But there's a certain kind of a respect to have for each other and the music I think.

MR: Do you, as a singer, you're usually the featured performer. Is that a fair statement?

GG: Yeah.

MR: So do you feel that you have the license to ask a person to play differently?

GG: It depends. If I hire musicians for a date then I'm hiring them to play what they play. I'm hiring them to play them. If I'm working with a trio and I don't know the trio, or even if I do, if I want less from somebody, or if I want more space, I don't have a problem in asking them for more space. And that's what I'll do. I'll ask them. Could you give me more space.

MR: That's the word you would use.

GG: Yeah.

MR: Okay.

GG: But I'm not going to tell anybody how to play. I might ask for someone to play softer, but I'll never say, "hey could you play more like Freddie Green?" I don't think that's right.

"Could you play more like Ben Riley?" "Well why don't you call Ben Riley if you wanted that?" I mean I had the good fortune to record with Ben Riley.

MR: No kidding.

GG: And there were several Monk tunes on the record that the record company cat, Marc Edelman from Sharp Nine Records. It was David Hazeltine on piano, Peter Washington, Jim Rotundi on trumpet, and Ben Riley. I show up and I see Ben Riley and I went wow. We're doing "Epistrophy" with my lyrics, "Ask Me Now," "Speed Ball," a couple of tunes like that. And Ben Riley is looking at the list of songs. And he says to me, "you a tenor player?" I said, "no, I'm a singer." Can I use French on this?

MR: Of course.

GG: He said to me, "a singer? You going to sing this shit?" I said, "yes, sir." He said, "my man." So that, I mean there you go. I mean Ben Riley, I got all the respect in the world for Ben Riley. But he was happy that I was singing "Speed Ball" and "Night in Tunisia" because I'm singing a real, what I like to think of as a real jazz repertoire.

MR: That's a good story, and it's very interesting that you showed up for this date and you didn't know he was on it, right?

GG: No.

MR: And he didn't know who was the soloist on this date either. The way that thing works is, I think, very interesting. It's always sort of been that way in jazz. You just are prepared or don't be in the business.

GG: Yeah, yeah, yeah. And there's a certain kind of a coming together, hopefully. It's a supportive thing. Everybody's supporting each other, especially from that era, to me. Musicians used to play to make each other sound good, as opposed to, "okay it's my turn to shine." You know? When somebody was soloing, I mean they would comp to make him sound better. Whoever was playing drums would make it happen. Kick the singer. Kick the tenor player. Whatever. I had somebody tell me one time, doing a gig, and the guitar player didn't know the bass player and the drummer. And when they arrived in their cars, the bass player and the drummer were riding together. And the guitar player said to me, "nice. I like to see them pull up together." Because they're going to play together if they hang together. At least one likes to think so. And it usually does happen that way.

MR: You ever have any train wrecks?

GG: Oh, big ones man. The one that I can think of offhand that comes to me, it's funny and it was a real learning experience for me. I got put with a quartet. Piano, bass, drums and an alto player, to do a festival. An indoor festival. And everything was going fine. We were about 3/4 of the way through the set. And it's like this it's bass, drums, alto, piano. And I turned to the band and I say, "rhythm changes in E flat." Then I turned to the audience

and say, "George and Ira Gershwin wrote a song called 'I Got Rhythm.' Lester Young composed a melody over 'I Got Rhythm' and he called it 'Lester Leaps In.' The lyrical version is called 'I Got the Blues.'" I turned to the band and say, "one/two/one-two-three-four." Now maybe they weren't listening. But the bass player — you know where this is going already, right? The bass player and the drummer start to play rhythm changes. And the piano player and the alto player are playing the blues. Now that works for about two measures. Then it kind of goes in different directions. Now I'm trying to sing [sings] I got the blues and I don't know how to lose them/I got the blues and I don't know what to do. Boom. That's where it changes. And I feel this shift happen. So I'm leaning into the bass player so I can hear "I Got Rhythm" and these guys are playing something else. And I'm trying to give them the signal or something, and it's not happening. So by the time I get into the solo, they get it. And we hook up. So we finished the set and Buster Williams and his group are coming up next. But Buster is sitting in the like the fourth row. And when we come off and they're going up, he's laughing so hard, and I had met him a little bit before that. He's cracking up. He said, "man, that was the funniest thing I ever saw." He says, "you were bound and determined to sing 'I Got Rhythm.'" So he said, "but you know it worked." He said, "because some people didn't hear it, they didn't get it; some people thought hmm, this is interesting; or some people knew what was happening, maybe only a few, the musicians might have known. So yeah, that was very uncomfortable. There was probably like 1,500 people in the audience. But what I learned was, if that happens, stop. Start over. So what, we made a mistake. You know? We breathe. We walk around, sometimes we trip. Lord Buckley said, "to err is human and to forgive is a gasser." So stop, start over.

MR: Interesting.

GG: I wouldn't do that again.

MR: Yeah. I mean I always tell my students if you make a mistake keep going. But you're describing something a little different.

GG: Yeah, a mistake is one thing. But this was like a collision. And you know, what does that mean? It's a big stage with too many monitors. So you can't hear anything, to me. I mean this music is acoustic music. The more monitors they put up there the less you can hear.

MR: Oh what a good statement.

GG: Because they probably couldn't hear it. "Give me more me in the monitors." "No, give me more of them" except for me, I need to hear me or else I'm going to sing in a different key.

MR: Yeah I know what you mean. Like you can hear everything and nothing. It's like loud but you can't hear. It's a very weird situation that we find ourselves in often.

GG: Last night the sound was fantastic in the club. We started out with acoustic piano, an upright. The piano was miced. There were a couple of monitors and I think the bass was in one of the monitors, and so was I. It's a little room. You know how it ended up? Acoustic piano with the top taken off. You know it's an upright so they took the top off. And take the mic off the bass and have him come through his amp. The drummer played mostly brushes. Now I don't have to holler. So we could all hear, they can hear, you hear all the nuances. You know it's not rock & roll. We're not trying to fill a stadium.

MR: Right. And people listen more intently if they're not being —

GG: Yeah. If their hair's not moving.

MR: You entered the business, I would say, in the digital age, right?

GG: Yeah.

MR: Do you have an opinion about the way music is sold these days?

GG: Yeah. Well the very first company that I got hooked up with, DMP Records, the first CD company to do quadrasound — that was interesting, because they were an audiophile company, not really a jazz company. So they were into the recording of it. But I know what you mean, you mean the sale of the music? Is that what you were referring to?

MR: Say it again?

GG: The sale of the music?

MR: Yes. It occurs to me because you're on Pandora and everybody's on —

GG: Something.

MR: And do you feel that you ever get any compensation for the fact that anybody can access your music at any time.

GG: You know it's nice that people can hear you that formerly couldn't. On the other hand, it makes — I don't know — it makes the music less important. If it's that easy to get it then what's the big deal. I know record companies are in a spin. They don't know how to make it happen. You know, Facebook, YouTube, I mean I have no idea how much stuff is on YouTube of things that I've done. And you know what? I'm not that crazy about it. Because if — I think I'm a pretty in-tune singer. But I've heard stuff on YouTube it's like my God, what key am I singing in? Sometimes, you know that little 42 dollar thing that they're recording you on is junk. So by the time they post it, it sounds bad, it looks worse, so somebody who doesn't know what you do or somebody who doesn't have a real recording looks at it and goes, "I'll never go see that."

MR: And you have no control over who puts up what.

GG: No. I mean you could say, "please, no live recordings." Yeah right. I mean if people have something in their pocket and they have it on. So not only do they get a bad recording but they have the rustle of their clothing to go with it.

MR: Times change. You know I was looking at some of the things people have said about you. This is from your website and it's nice. You got a nice quote from Dave Brubeck.

GG: Yeah.

MR: You've got someone from the *Topeka Journal* said you were the Dennis Hopper of vocal jazz.

GG: Yeah, that's pretty wild, huh?

MR: But he called you a musician. He says, "he's not just a jazz singer, he's a musician." So that's nice.

GG: That's nice. I appreciate that.

MR: Have you seen reviews that aren't as kind?

GG: I've seen a couple. One of the very first travel gigs that I ever did, I was brand new. I did a festival in Clearwater, Florida. And I was a feature. I was a quick feature in the band and it was probably like a quartet. You know, rhythm section with a saxophone and a vibraphone, and I was part of it. And I was referred to as something like a "poor man's Eddie Jefferson" or something like that. But you know what? I mean there are a lot of artists that I have heard say well I pay no attention to the reviews. It's hard to do. I mean you take things personally. You can't help it. We breathe. So it's nice to read something that's nice, and it's not to read something that's not. On the other hand, and, you know, sometimes someone will say something really nice about someone. And then they say something nice about someone else that's like, I think they're not happening. So what is the valid quotient here? Do you like everybody? Because if you like everybody then you're just being kind you know, or you're just doing the job. It's my job to review, and I don't want to say anything bad. Well then that kind of levels everything out. So I mean it's personal. You know if you like what I do, solid. If you don't, but then there's the thing about like critics who review plays. What did I just see? I saw something. Oh, I just saw the film "Birdman." Was it Birdman"? Yeah it was "Birdman." I don't know, it was something, a movie that I saw and the person who was in the play is — yeah it was "Birdman." The person who was in the play approaches a theater critic, before the thing takes place. And the critic says to the star, he says, "listen," he says, "I'm going to bury this thing." He said, "you haven't even seen it yet." "I don't like you and I don't like your play. I haven't seen it, and I'm going to close you down in a week." Well they've got a lot of power. So if they want to they can turn a lot of people off to you. Or they can turn a lot of people on to you. So, you know, it's kind of weird — I'm gassed, what people have written about me. But it's kind of weird. You know, somebody's got a lot of juice to be able to put the thumb on you if they want to.

MR: Part of the business.

GG: Yeah, part of the business. I mean if you're going to expose yourself to be out there then you've got to go along with that. It's going to happen. Not everybody likes what everybody does.

MR: Right. Okay. Name this tune, you ready? [hums "Centerpiece"].

GG: [sings] The more I feel my love increase. "Centerpiece."

MR: Okay. So here's what you did with —
[audio interlude]
Right there.

GG: I got in front.

MR: You got in front.

GG: Singers get behind, not many get in front. But I just kind of heard it that way. And if I work with a rhythm section where I've never worked with and I tell them I'm going to do that and maybe I'll open with that, I'll tell them, "listen, I know where I am. You know, you cats just play the map, I know where I am." Because lots of times they'll adjust, "uh oh, he doesn't know where he is." The singer. That's a singer thing. "Oh the singer's lost, let's adjust." Well they should. But they should tell the singer, say, "listen, we had to adjust to you baby, because you were out of whack." "Oh really?" Because some don't know that. But the piano player will never tell the singer because the singer might get an attitude. So I let them know, I know where I am. You don't have to adjust. We'll meet back up again and then I'm going to let you go and then I'll catch you again. And they'll go, "solid." In fact, I had a wonderful opportunity to sing a few times with Jon Hendricks, Aria Hendricks and Kevin Burke, when it was Lambert, Hendricks, uh, Jon Hendricks and Company. And they said, "come on up here, man." And they were going to do "Centerpiece." And I got like — like instead of singing in the harmony, because they're great with their harmonies. I let them sing in their harmony and I was kind of like around it somewhere. And Jon looked at me and grinned. And that made me feel like all right, I'm in now. You know?

MR: Yeah. A grin from Jon Hendricks.

GG: Yeah.

MR: How do you teach people to do that?

GG: To mess with the time?

MR: Yeah.

GG: I think metronomes are really important. Most singers hate them. Most musicians don't like them because they've got this ugly click-click. But that's — I tell them, I explain to them I say, "a long time ago metronomes were these big clumsy things that you'd wind up. Then they made them so you could plug them in the wall. Now they make them really small. So buy the smallest one you can, put fresh batteries in it, and swallow it. That way

you'll always have good time." Because time is what makes it happen. I mean I don't want to hear somebody out of tune, but I'd rather hear them out of tune than out of time. Because if you're in time at least there's a groove. I mean I don't want to hear out of tune either, but time, to me — I've been really fortunate in being around some musicians that I was buying their LPs when I was a kid. Eddie Bert said to me, "you know why we swing? Because we used to play for dancers. And we know how to swing. Because if they're not dancing, we're not swinging. And if they're dancing and they're swinging, they make the band swing even more." So I also got lucky to play for dancers for a while. I used to play Lindy dances. I mean it was retro. It was like when people started to dance again, with dance societies. And I would get a call to play with the band, to sing a few numbers, because people were going to dance. And man the band would be swinging. So a lot of people don't have the opportunity to play for dancers. That was a whole 'nother thing. We don't want to play for people to dance. We just want people to listen. I want people to want to dance. That means we're swinging.

MR: Yeah. Even if they can't. Even if there's no room they can feel it.

GG: Yeah. They can groove at least. That's what this music is supposed to be. It's supposed to be a toe-tapper. Even if it's slow. It's supposed to make you feel some kind of pulse, some kind of momentum.

MR: All right. I'm going to try another — whoops wrong button. I'm sure you'll recognize yourself.

[audio interlude]

I love it. Tell me about your creative process. This, for those who are watching, this is "Miles Tones." This is your most recent one, right?

GG: Um hum. Well I have to like the melody. I have to like the melody. Because those are my lyrics to "Milestones." And I have to like the melody. Because it's got to be lyrical. It's got to be singable. It's got to be hummable. So if I like the melody enough, and I listen to it enough, and then I go by the title. I refer to the title. Right? What's this about. Well it's about milestones. What are milestones? Yardsticks? Meters? Inches? Measurement. Can you measure life? And you live with it for a while. The melody. You just keep, I keep listening to it, I keep humming it, and after a while you start to hear words (either that or I'm losing my mind) but you just start to hear a theme in there and then, the encapsulation is it takes me a half an hour to write lyrics to a song. But I listened to it for three months. So I listen to it and listen to it, and it starts to speak, and I start to get a gist of what it means for me.

MR: You know that song has a thing that I wonder, the A section is very up, and then the bridge is much more flowing.

GG: Right.

MR: Did that direct your choice of words?

GG: I think it had something to do with it, yeah, I think so. Plus Miles was very lyrical you know, left space to breathe. Left space to think or not think, to just feel it.

MR: Do you think it's — I don't know if easier is the right word — but to scat sing or improvise over the modal changes that last 16 bars as opposed to trying to scat sing over like bop changes that are moving quicker?

GG: Yeah. On one hand the modal is easier, on the other hand, you'd better do something because there's not a lot going on. Can I do my bad Chet Baker impersonation about improvisation?

MR: Sure.

GG: Somebody asked him, they said, "I'd like to take a lesson with you in improvisation." And Chet, who is a little salty sometimes, said, "well improvisation is about imagination or lack of it." So I always remembered that. You'd better have something to say, otherwise don't say much. Say a little then get out. A long, long time ago I went to a jam session at a club in Seaford, Long Island called Sonny's Place. It was a club that was there for many years and many great players and singers stopped in there just to play for Sonny. And I called up to get a date there and Sonny said to me, "well come in on a Wednesday night, we have a jam session. If we like what you do we'll give you a date." So I show up and it's a rhythm section and a tenor player. But the tenor player is Billy Mitchell of the Count Basie band. And this was probably mid or early 90s. Another guy who was not that fond of singers because he wanted to hear somebody who had something to say, or maybe even instrumentalists who had something to say. So I remember sitting down and the band plays the first set. And then they take a break and then they open it up. And there's like four alto players and three tenor players lined up. And Billy Mitchell says on the microphone, I won't use his expletives, but he said, "well I see we've got a lot of horn players tonight, so when you come up here, don't play more than two choruses. Charlie Parker was a bad mickey-fickey, and he never played more than four." So right away the horn players are putting their horns away now. You know? So I'm thinking wow, this is the real deal here. He's not giving nobody no slack. So I finally get called up, and I get called up on the very last set because, well, "we'll let the singer come up when it's over." He says, "well what do you got?" I said, "well could we do 'In Walked Bud'?" He says, "yeah." So I turned to the piano player. I said, "is F minor all right," which is the standard key. And Billy says to me, "never mind what key it's in, just sing it." The bebop test. So I sing the song. And I scat a chorus and they play, and we take it out. And I turned to Billy Mitchell and I said, "Mr. Mitchell, thank you very much for letting me sit in with you. It was an honor." And I go to walk away and he grabbed my shirt. He says, "wait a minute. As long as you're up here you might as well sing

another one." I said, "yes indeed." So to be accepted by somebody who I looked up to, I wouldn't have cared if he threw me off the bandstand. Because that's what they do. But to be accepted like that is like just huge for me. I mean I drove home, it was like a two hour drive home, I'm going like, "wow, Billy Mitchell said it was okay." And then I got a gig, about three months later. He [Sonny] gave me a date that night, for three months down the road. And I showed up with a rhythm section with guys that I knew from Long Island. And on the first set I see Billy Mitchell walk in with his horn. And on the break he said to me, "hey man, from the song" — and the second song I sang, I don't know what it was, but I think it was something like "Confirmation" or something like that. He said to me, "from the songs that you sang when you sat in, I figured you'd have to bring a pretty good rhythm section. Do you mind if I sit in?" And I said, "do I mind if you sit in?" I said, "Mr. Mitchell, you put a chair on the bandstand and you stay as long as you like." And he just smiled. "That's right, baby." Billy Mitchell sitting in? Come on. So that to me is worth a lot. You know? I mean I never had big representation or any of that other stuff. That made it happen. Lou Donaldson saying, "yeah man, come on up." You know. "Yeah a friend of mine, come on up and sing a tune, Gates."

MR: Gates. Yeah you can't buy that. That's a great feeling to be accepted into that fraternity.

GG: Of the hard core guys who don't cut nobody no baloney.

MR: Right.

GG: It made me feel like it was all right.

MR: All right. Name this guy.

[audio interlude]

GG: That's Mr. Williams. Big Joe Williams.

MR: We had a great relationship with him actually. He helped us get this project started. He had a relationship with Hamilton College and he got an honorary degree there, so I got to be in his presence on occasion. Those guys had an aura, some of them.

GG: Yeah, yeah.

MR: And I don't know where it came from.

GG: Yeah. There's a glow. I don't know where it comes from either but yeah, I sure do recognize it in some people. He was one of the first people that I heard with big bands, because my father played Count Basie. So I heard Joe Williams with Count Basie. And he's got a very distinctive sound. Maybe I read this somewhere but he was like the first gentleman blues singer. You know, articulate. His notes were right on. He didn't — I mean I don't know what Mr. Williams did but he never sounded like he was drunk. A lot of blues singers sounded like [slurs words] but he was articulate and enunciation was right on. But he sang some sure enough blues.

MR: Oh yeah. Okay I got one more for you here. This has always mystified me.

[audio interlude]

GG: LHR.

MR: Say that again?

GG: LHR. Lambert, Hendricks & Ross.

MR: Oh yeah. Okay.

GG: Oh that's Jon. Is that the live recording in San Francisco or something like that?

MR: That came from the LP. I just don't know, how does a person articulate that fast?

GG: It's muscle memory. You just do it so many times, so many times, so many times, that it's muscle memory. I mean I watch somebody like you play the piano I say wow, man. I mean I can play anything as long as it's rubato. But when I see people play I say how do people do that? Well, they practice. And here's one that I came up with. Some people call it rehearsal. Some people call it practicing. I call it what it really is: tedious repetition. You do it enough times you're going to get good at it. You keep doing it, keep doing it, keep doing it, until you don't have to think about it. Then it just happens. Then you can enjoy it while it's happening as opposed to working at it to get it through. You say, yeah, I'm along for the ride. And I think that's what people like Jon did. Because when I started to learn that kind of material I said, "how do they get this off?" Well you do it until you've got it. And you have to listen to yourself, and you have to be critical enough to say — I mean the first time I saw myself videotaped, videotaped, you know, VHS? I went to — I was given the videotape but I went to a lady friend's house, because she had a VHS player and I didn't. So we watched and it was like 25 minutes. And then it was over and she got up to go into the kitchen to make a cup of tea or something, and I rewound it and started to watch it again. And she came back into the living room and she said, "oh you like to watch yourself, don't you." I said, "on the contrary, this is making me really uncomfortable. But I'm going to watch this to find out what I don't like and try to fix it." So I think that's what you have to do. If you're satisfied with it all the time then it's not going to go anywhere. But I think that that rapid fire — you have to be inclined to want to do that, and have maybe the possibility of getting it off. But you have to work at it. You don't just do it. I mean Jon Hendricks is amazing. He's amazing. And every time I would get something of his I'd say, "wow, this is the better than the last one." And then I mean "Freddie Freeloader," did you ever hear that?

MR: Yeah.

GG: It's amazing what he wrote, and that he sings a John Coltrane solo. I mean who could sing a John Coltrane solo? Jon Hendricks.

MR: Speaking of that. Are you a fan of the Coltrane type music and that era where people played on and on and on?

GG: When John Coltrane played out, at least I know where he is. Some people play out and I don't know where they are. You know. I'm not a fan of out. A little bit out, but I want to hear the song, or I want to hear a reference to a song. I want to know where the band is, where everybody is. For those who haven't heard it, when Coltrane said to Miles, or Miles said to Coltrane, "listen man, you've got to stop playing those 45 minute solos. People are walking out." And Coltrane says, "well I finish a chorus and I come up with another idea, so I want to play that idea, and when I finish that idea I thought I left this out or I got another idea and I want to play that. I don't know how to stop." And Miles said, "just take the horn out your mouth." You know? So I think anyway you have to realize that you are performing for an audience. I mean some people want to come and see you go off into oblivion. And some people don't. Especially if you're a singer anyway. I want to be challenging but accessible. I want people to get it. I don't want people to go out and go, "what happened in there?" I want them to hear it. Even if it's something that they never heard before. I want to walk out, if I go listen to someone, I want to walk out humming something. I want to hear some kind of something.

MR: Something to take home.

GG: Yeah, something to take home.

MR: You mentioned the *Great American Songbook*, which is such a part of what singers and instrumentalists do. And I'm wondering, when you choose songs from that book, that era, I'm not sure how to ask this question, but some songs date well and some not so well.

GG: Yeah, no, I understand that.

MR: So do you make a distinction about what you're going to sing from the lyric, if you feel funny singing it now?

GG: I think that there are some songs that I feel like naa, this is too dated, as far as maybe a lyrical reference to some things.

MR: That's just what I was thinking about. Like that song, "I Can't Get Started," he's talking about the Prince of Wales and starting a revolution in Spain.

GG: Right. I mean I think those are great lyrics. I don't know if everybody will get it or if they will go oh this is dated. I mean I don't mind dated. I don't mind the reference to something that happened in a different time. Lenny Bruce did a thing one time where he said, "I feel just like Walli Simpson." And I'm like, Walli Simpson? Who's Walli Simpson? Wallis Simpson was the woman who the Prince of England fell in love with and gave up his throne for. Well I didn't get it until I started to figure it — I researched, who is Walli Simpson. And he was referencing that he gave something up for something. Someone gave something up and he said, "I feel just like Walli Simpson." So if you don't know the reference then it's too inside. I mean I want to be stretched a little bit but I don't want to be left in the dark. And some things are — when you started to ask me that

question, —when cabs don't drive around the park — there's a song — when cabs don't drive around the park, "Will You Still be Mine." There's some great references to, I mean when you hear the lyric you feel 1945 New York City. To me that's nice. But if it excludes everybody —

MR: Okay.

GG: You know. I just cut a record for HighNote again. I'm happy to be with them. And it's all very esoteric music. Babs Gonsales, an Elvis Costello tune — that's not esoteric but for me to include Elvis Costello's music what I do to me is a stretch. But I do a bit by Lenny Bruce that Lenny did with Steve Allen. It's not dated. It's so today. So that kind of stuff, I mean I want to be turned on to something different. So I hope that somebody who comes to see what I do wants to get turned on to something different. Because it broadens your hat size.

MR: Hat size. I've got to borrow that one too. That's great. So I know you have to get on the road. Do you have a piece of advice for aspiring singers? What should they always have?

GG: Lots of air. Breathe deep. Don't interrupt yourself when you sing. [sings] She gets too hungry for dinner [exaggerated breath] at eight. Don't do that. Listen to Frank [Sinatra]. Nobody breathes better than that you know. I mean I'm a big fan of Dean Martin.

MR: No kidding.

GG: You want to learn how to sing, as far as like being relaxed and not take yourself too serious, watch Dean Martin. He's having a great time, he sings in tune, he sings in time, he's not drunk. You know. I mean I like a lot of singers. Anita O'Day. I listen to a lot of female singers. Anita O'Day, she's fantastic. Carmen [McRae] I mean everybody knows Carmen, Sarah [Vaughan], Ella [Fitzgerald]. You know, Billie [Holiday]. Anita O'Day. I don't sing like Chet Baker, I don't sing like Jimmy Scott, but I sure can listen to them. So listen to all the greats. Listen to all the horn players who play songs.

MR: Yeah, you said that, I know you said that, "some of my biggest influences are sax players."

GG: Yeah. You know let me reiterate another story. I mean these are stories that we probably know. The Ben Webster story where he's doing a record of ballads. And he's one take right after the other. One take, that's a take, okay next. Next take. They get to like the fifth tune and they're playing and Ben just stops. So everybody stops and the engineer says, "Ben, is there a problem?" He says, "yeah, man, I forgot the words." He's playing a tenor. "Yeah but I forgot the words." So it's important to tell a story and to be connected to the story. If you can't connect, sing something that you can connect to. I mean I'll probably never record "I Feel Pretty."

MR: All right. I won't expect that from you. Maybe you could describe someone else who's feeling pretty and put that spin on it.

GG: Yeah like that.

MR: Well all right. On that note I appreciate your coming today.

GG: Thank you. It was a pleasure. It was a really a pleasure. You know, you're fun.

MR: Okay. Over and out.

GG: Over and out.